

D20



THE BARON OF FLAME

— A D20 ONE-SHOT MODULE —

Rules of the Game: D20

INITIAL SETUP

- **Player Order:** Each player rolls a d20. Highest roll goes first, proceeding to lowest. Re-roll ties.
- **Character Creation:** Start at Level 5. Choose a GM-approved class, base skill, and one weapon (*If Allowed*).

TURN STRUCTURE

- **Turn Composition:** One move and one action (attack, skill, environment interaction) per scene.
- **Scenes:** A full turn rotation. Players can interact within a scene. Next scene begins when all finish.

COMBAT MECHANICS

- **Skill Checks:** Roll d20. Success requires a result equal to or higher than the GM target number.
- **Combat Order:** Uses turn order. Enemies roll a d20 to join the active round sequence.
- **Maximum Health:** Current Level * 20 (Example: Level 5 = 100 Max HP).
- **Attack Damage:** Current Level * Attacker's d20 Roll.
- **Defense Value:** Current Level * Defender's d20 Roll.
- **Damage Resolution:** If Defense Value $\geq$ Attack Value, the attack is fully blocked. Otherwise:
 - *Final Damage = Attack Damage - Defense Value*

LEVELING UP & PROGRESSION

- **Leveling:** Gain up to 3 levels per scene via battles, events, or artifacts.
- **Skill Points:** Gain 2 bonus stat points at each prime-number level after Level 5.
- **Submission:** Once finalized, stats can not be changed.

CORE ATTRIBUTES DEFINED

- **Might:** Governs physical strength, striking power, pushing, pulling, and lifting.
- **Vigor:** Governs toughness, damage endurance, and resistance to poisons or alcohol.
- **Agility:** Governs sleight of hand, stealth, fixing, acrobatics, and ranged weapon accuracy.
- **Mind:** Governs knowledge, understanding, speaking, and logical reasoning.
- **Instinct:** Governs sensory awareness, quick reflexes, and subconscious reactions.

INVENTORY MANAGEMENT

- **Item Capacity:** Maximum limit of 3 items, unless modified by unique gear.
- **Restrictions:** Starting gear and items must be class-appropriate and GM-approved.

RESTRICTIONS & ENDGAME

- **Class Changes:** Strictly locked unless specifically authorized by the GM.
- **Artifact Rules:** Properties and effects are permanently fixed once defined by the GM.
- **Starting Location:** All characters begin in the same story location together.
- **Endgame:** The session ends when the GM-defined goal is finished (e.g., clearing a quest or boss).

MISCELLANEOUS

- **Game Master's Role:** The GM acts as the absolute final arbiter of rules, challenges, and disputes.
- **Interaction:** Creative role-playing and active player cooperation are highly encouraged.

THE BARON OF FLAME

THE ORIGINS OF THE EMBRES' HERO — A D20 ONE-SHOT CAMPAIGN

INTRODUCTION

In the Town of Embres, there have been sightings of mysterious flames igniting in the noble district around the manor of the deceased Baron. Explore the town, uncover the source of the flames, and save Embres before it is consumed by fire. All in this one-shot campaign.

CAMPAIGN OVERVIEW

Seven years ago, the noble district of Embres was devastated by a fire that claimed the life of the Baron and his family. The cause of the fire was never determined, but rumors of dark magic and a vengeful spirit have persisted ever since. Recently, there have been sightings of mysterious flames igniting in the noble district around the manor of the deceased Baron. The townsfolk are terrified, and the local authorities are at a loss for how to stop it. As adventurers, you have been called upon to investigate the source of the flames and put an end to the threat before it consumes the entire town. Your journey will take you through the streets of Embres, into the heart of the noble district, and ultimately to the manor itself, where you will confront the source behind the flames.

THE BACKSTORY (GAME MASTER REFERENCE ONLY)

Seven years ago, a monstrous ogre disguised as a human woman kidnapped the infant Grant from his family, murdering his mother in the process. To cover her tracks, she set a fire that quickly spun out of control, destroying the entire noble district. During the tragedy, the Baron sacrificed his life to save his loyal butler. The Baron possessed a rare family gift: when a close comrade died, their memory could endure as a fiery skeletal wraith. Though the butler initially survived the blaze, he passed away shortly after. Driven by the Baron's lingering magic, the butler's memory manifested as a blazing wraith bound to a single directive: Protect the Baron's bloodline. The kidnapper raised Grant, acting as his "guardian" while keeping his true identity as the Baron's son a secret. Now, seven years later, Grant has begun wandering near the ruins of his ancestral home, drawing the protective wraith out of hiding and sparking the mysterious fires around the untouched manor.

ADVENTURE HOOK

The party begins their journey arriving at the gates of Embres under an official contract: The Town Council's Bounty: The local authorities have pooled their gold to hire outside mercenaries to investigate the supernatural fires in the ruined noble district and extinguish the threat before it spreads to the lower districts.

Character Creation & Player Primer

CHARACTER RACES

HUMAN

Humans are adaptable and resilient builders who founded the settlement of Embres. They lack specialized anatomical traits but possess unmatched determination.

PASSIVES

- **Versatile:** Gain +1 to any two different skill checks of your choice.

SKILLS

- *None*

ELF

Elves are deeply attuned to the lingering ambient magical energies flowing through the region. Their sharp eyes miss nothing amidst the smoke and ruins.

PASSIVES

- **Keen Senses:** Gain +2 to all perception-based checks.

SKILLS

- *None*

BEASTMAN

Possessing raw, feral power and sharp animalistic instincts, Beastmen rely on physical prowess to dominate the battlefield and survive harsh elements.

PASSIVES

- *None*

SKILLS

- **Savage Attack:** Once per battle, deal an extra 1d20 damage after a successful hit.

CHARACTER CLASSES

KNIGHT

front-line protectors who use tactical martial training to draw enemy focus and shield fragile allies from harm.

PASSIVES

- **Sword Mastery:** Gain +1 item slot for Swords.
(Assigned to Slot S)

SKILLS

- **Taunt:** Force an enemy to target you instead of allies for one turn.

ARCHER

Master marksmen who control the battlefield from afar, utilizing flawless precision to target anatomical weaknesses in enemy defense.

PASSIVES

- **Quiver Mastery:** Gain +1 item slot for bows. Never run out of standard arrows.

SKILLS

- **Piercing Shot:** Ignore defense on your next attack.
Requires a bow equipped.

MAGICIAN

Scholars of esoteric disciplines who channel devastating raw elemental destruction through attuned catalysts and specialized implements.

PASSIVES

- **There's My Wand!:** Gain +1 item slot for magical wands or catalysts.

SKILLS

- **Elemental Burst:** Deal +1d20 bonus damage based on Affinity (*Earth, Fire, Wind, Water*) on hit.

ACT I: THE SPARKS OF EMBRES

SCENE 1: THE HEARTH & EMBERS TAVERN

The campaign begins inside the main hub of the lower district: a bustling, slightly chaotic tavern ran by a hardworking local named Bram.

READ ALOUD TO PLAYERS

The heavy door of the Hearth & Embers Tavern swings shut behind you, cutting off the damp, smoky air of Embres. Inside, the tavern is warm but chaotic. A weary-eyed human man balances a massive tray of stews while shouting orders toward the kitchen. Weaving through the crowded tables are three young girls, roughly seven years old, trying their best to help carry wooden mugs and wipe down tables. The tavern is lively, but it is clear this single father is stretched to his absolute limit trying to run the business and raise his daughters alone.

RUNNING THE SCENE

The Innkeeper (Bram): Friendly, exhausted, and deeply devoted to his family. If the players speak with him, he reveals his wife passed away some time ago. He runs the tavern alone to support his three daughters. The Daughters (Amber, Ash, and Eve): Each sister has a distinct personality that dictates how they interact with the party: Ash: Headstrong and stubborn. She tries to carry objects that are way too heavy for her, refuses help from customers, and stomps her foot if anyone calls her small. Amber: The moderate balancer. She acts as the peacekeeper between her sisters, making sure Ash doesn't break dishes and gently encouraging Eve to stay involved. Eve: Quiet and shy. She hides behind her father's apron or Amber's shoulder, quietly sliding stews to customers before darting away. The Lore Drop: While serving the party, Bram sighs and mentions the town's troubles. He explains that seven years ago, a massive fire claimed the entire noble district. The Baron and his family died in the blaze, but the Baron's manor survived completely untouched. Lately, mysterious flames have been igniting around the ruins, scaring away travelers and hurting his business.

SCENE 2: THE ALLEYWAY COMMOTION

The tavern scene is interrupted when the back alley doors click open. The sisters rush back inside, their reactions perfectly reflecting their personalities.

READ ALOUD TO PLAYERS

The back door rattles open. Eve slips inside first, wide-eyed, completely silent, and trembling as she tugs frantically on her father's sleeve. Amber follows right behind, her voice tense but measured as she explains, "Dad, someone needs to go out there, the older boys are acting up again." Suddenly, Ash marches past both of them toward the front door, grabbing a heavy wooden rolling pin with a stubborn scowl. "They're messing with Grant again!" she yells. Through the window, you see the commotion: three older, aggressive youths have backed a small, dirt-faced boy into a corner.

RUNNING THE ENCOUNTER

The Conflict: Three local bullies are tormenting 7-year-old Grant. The Resolution: The players can step outside to intervene using intimidation, charm, or basic physical force. The bullies are cowards and will flee if the party shows any real authority. If the players wait too long, Ash will stubbornly try to march out there herself! The Connection: Once saved, Grant retrieves his scorched wooden knight. Ash proudly crosses her arms, Amber brings him a warm towel to wipe the dirt off his face, and Eve quietly slides him a hot bowl of soup.

SCENE 3: THE GUARDIAN'S HEARTH

Grateful for the party's help, Grant offers to take them to meet his Guardian at their home just down the street, promising she can help give them information on the ruins. Sitting at a wooden table inside is his Guardian—a tall, physically imposing woman who wears an overly tight, worn apron and handles heavy iron cooking pots with ease.

ROLEPLAYING THE GUARDIAN

The Persona: She puts on the facade of a deeply weary, protective adoptive mother who took in a street orphan out of the goodness of her heart. She is outwardly polite to the party but is secretly tense about heavily armed adventurers interacting with Grant.

THE DECEPTIVE STORY (THE FIRE & THE LEGEND)

If the players ask about the town's history or why the noble district is burning, the Guardian pours them a drink, sighs deeply, and tells them the history: *"Seven years ago, this town was paradise. The Baron of Embres was a good man, a former adventurer who used his wealth to build this colony. But paradise burns fast. One night, a fire started in the noble district. No one knows how, but some say it was dark magic or a curse. The flames spread like a living beast, consuming the entire district in minutes. The Baron, his beautiful wife, and their newborn infant child were trapped inside their burning home. They all perished in the ash. The only thing that survived was the Baron's Manor itself—standing completely untouched by the fire, as if mocking the dead. Ever since that night, the ruins have been cursed. The supernatural flames you see today are the vengeful spirit of the dead Baron, angry that his life and lineage were cut short. Stay away from that place. It brings nothing but death."*

HER COVER STORY: HOW SHE FOUND GRANT

If the players ask how Grant came to be in her care, or if they notice Grant is the exact same age as the tragedy, she smoothly transitions into her fabricated story: *"A few months after the great fire, when the smoke finally cleared from the lower districts, I found Grant. He was just a tiny, abandoned infant wrapped in dirty rags, left on the doorstep of the town chapel. The monks couldn't afford to feed another mouth, and my heart broke for the poor thing. With the Baron gone and the town in shambles, nobody was looking out for the orphans. I took him in and raised him as my own. He's a good boy, but he's obsessed with those cursed ruins. I keep him close because I refuse to let the ash take him like it took everyone else seven years ago."*

RUNNING THE SCENE (THE DISAGREEMENT)

The Proposition: Grant looks up at the party's gear and offers an idea: "You look like you know how to fight! If you're going into the ash fields, I can show you the secret way past the rubble to get right up to the manor doors!" The Shutdown: The Guardian's facade drops for a split second. She slams her fist onto the wooden table, strictly forbidding it. She scolds Grant for wanting to go near the cursed ruins, orders him to his room immediately, and demands the party leave her house if they intend to trespass in the noble district. GM Note: If the players actively choose to check for deception during either of her stories, roll her against the system's standard deception mechanics. If they succeed, they notice her hand subtly twitches and she casts a sharp, possessive glance toward Grant when lying about finding him.

SCENE 4: THE ESCAPE & THE WRAITH'S WARNING

As the party exits the front door of the house and steps back into the cool, smoky evening air, they don't have to wait long for Grant to make his move.

THE ESCAPE

The Visual: A low, rhythmic hissing sound comes from the side of the house. If the players turn around, they see a wooden window shutter on the second floor pushed open just a crack. The Action: Grant leans out, frantically waving his arms to get the party's attention. He drops a small rope bundle, slides down onto a low rain barrel, and runs up to the players in the shadows of the alleyway. The Guide: Grinning stubbornly, he whispers, "I told you I know the way! Follow me, I know how to get past the main rubble blocks without the guards or my guardian spotting us." Grant takes the lead, navigating the party through the winding, ash-choked paths of the ruined noble district.

THE AMBUSH

Just as Grant guides the party through a collapsed stone archway near the edge of the estate grounds, the ambient temperature rises rapidly. The heavy soot in the air begins to glow with an intense, fiery orange hue. The Encounter: A Flaming Skeletal Wraith—a floating skeleton completely cloaked in roaring orange flames—materializes directly from the heavy smoke hanging over the ruins. The Target: Rather than attacking the players, the wraith locks its glowing gaze on one of the older bullies from the tavern alley who happened to be loitering near the edge of the ruins. Before anyone can react, the wraith unleashes a torrent of blinding, supernatural heat, completely incinerating the bully where he stands, leaving nothing but scorched ash on the stone pavement.

THE CRITICAL CLUE

During the sudden horror of the attack, the wraith speaks. What the Party hears: A terrifying, deafening roar of snapping timber and crackling wind. There are no distinguishable words in the noise—just the raw, violent sound of a magical inferno. What Grant hears: Grant turns completely pale and stares blankly at the ash. Because of his hidden bloodline, the roaring fire translates perfectly in his mind into a deep, echoing voice saying: "None shall harm the Baron." The Result: When the party checks on the stunned boy, Grant hesitantly reveals what the fire just whispered directly to him. This realization directly contradicts the Guardian's story that the ghost is a random vengeful spirit out to destroy the whole town. The wraith then dissolves back into floating embers, leaving the front path to the untouched Baron's Manor wide open.

ACT II: THE UNTOUCHED MANOR THE SWORN-SHIELD WRAITH VISUAL PROFILE

When this creature manifests, use the following description to set an intimidating scene for your players: **The Head (The Horned Skull):** Its head is a striking, bone-white skull based on an ancestral horned mask. The crown features a smooth, clean bone structure that sweeps backward into two massive, sharp devil horns that smoke with intense fire. In place of standard eye sockets, it features two wide, prominent eyes that burn with a deep, glowing orange fire. The bottom edge of the skull terminates in sharp, jagged bone points instead of a full jaw. **The Body:** A legless, floating torso consisting entirely of a bare, sharp, calcified skeletal ribcage and an exposed spine. The entire bone framework is completely engulfed and wrapped in roaring orange and red flames. **The Claws:** Its skeletal arms terminate in disproportionately large, massive hands with elongated, razor-sharp claws that click together and glow white-hot at the tips with pure fire. **The Floating Core:** The creature has no legs; its blazing spine tapers off and ends cleanly in mid-air, hovering completely silently surrounded by a tight aura of roaring fire.

THE SIX PUZZLE ROOMS THE UNIVERSAL TRAP MECHANIC

The moment the players cross the threshold into any of the six rooms on the second floor, the door instantly slams shut behind them with a heavy, echoing thud. **The Fire Trap:** The metal doorknob ignites automatically, and the entire surface of the door bursts into roaring orange flames. **The Hazard:** Touching the knob or trying to break down the door deals intense fire damage based on your system rules. The door is completely impassable by physical or magical force while the flames burn. **The Resolution:** The fire on the door will only extinguish and unlock once the players solve the specific puzzle hidden within that room.

ROOM 1: THE BARON'S STUDY (THE WRITTEN CONTRACT)

This room is a grand, dust-free office lined with towering bookshelves. A heavy mahogany desk sits in the center of the room. **The Clue:** On top of the desk lies an unfinished letter written by the Baron to his wife. It details his deep love for his family, his pride in building

the colony of Embres, and his plans for his newborn child. However, the letter cuts off abruptly at the bottom line where he was signing his name, leaving a glaring, blank space. **The Puzzle:** The players must search the massive bookshelves to find the missing piece of his identity: a specific book titled *The Memoirs of the Embres Founder*. **The Interactive Action:** Once they locate the memoir and discover the Baron's true name, the players must return to the desk. They must physically pick up an old ink quill and write the correct name directly onto the letter, finishing the document. **The Reveal:** The moment the ink dries with the correct name, the handwritten signature ignites into small glowing embers. A section of the stone wall flashes white-hot with fire, permanently searing the true history into the room's woodwork. The fire on the exit door immediately snuffs out and unlocks.

ROOM 2: THE PARLOR OF THE FLAME BARONESS (THE LOST DREAM)

This room breaks the pattern of the other gauntlets. It is an odd, unsettling space designed like an intimate sitting room. A bright, crackling bonfire burns directly out of the stone floor in the center of the room. Against the far north wall rests a plush, elegant velvet couch. **The Oddity:** No matter how the roaring bonfire flickers or where the players stand, every single shadow in the room defies physics—stretching and pointing directly toward the couch on the north wall. **The Effect (Drowsiness):** As any player character approaches the north wall, a heavy, supernatural exhaustion washes over them. The closer they get to the couch, the more drowsy and heavy-lidded they feel. To solve the room, a player must willingly succumb to the fatigue and lay down upon the couch. **The Illusion:** The moment the player's eyes close, they instantly snap open into a dreamlike trance. The player finds their head resting comfortably on the lap of a beautiful woman made entirely out of dancing, shifting flames. The flames do not burn as it appears to be an illusion casted from the bonfire. The woman treats the player as if it is her husband.

THE FLAME BARONESS'S MONOLOGUE

The fiery woman strokes the player's hair and speaks in a soft, crackling voice that sounds like a comforting hearth: *"Look at you... you look so tired, my love. Rest. You have worked so hard to build this town for us, but tonight, you can... relax. I was just sitting here thinking about our future. I still can't believe it's finally happening. After all those long years of trying, of hoping, of praying to the embers... our little one is finally growing inside me. I can feel the warmth, a tiny spark of your flame already waiting to meet us. I was just daydreaming about what it will look like when they are born. We'll take them out into the valley, past the district gates where the air is sweet. You can show them the colony, and we can watch them take their very first steps right there in the grass. We'll teach them how to hold a wooden sword, how to be kind, and how to protect the people of Embres, just like his father does. We are going to have a perfect life here. Just you, me, and our beautiful baby. A real family..."* The warmth of the fire suddenly turns piercingly cold. The golden haze begins to bleed into dark, suffocating gray smoke. The woman's fiery smile falters, and her eyes glaze over with a profound, heartbreaking sorrow as she looks down at the player: *"But you already know, don't you? You know the smoke is coming. You know how the story ends..... and sadly, I will never be able to experience it."* The Reveal: The moment the words leave her lips, the fiery woman dissolves into a cloud of silent, floating embers. The player instantly snaps awake back on the physical couch. The central bonfire snuffs out entirely, leaving the room dark, and the roaring flames on the exit door vanish, unlocking the path forward.

ROOM 3: THE ARMORY OF VOWS (THE SWORN SHIELD)

This chamber is a cold, stone armory lined with weapon racks and empty display stands. Two prominent, life-sized iron suits of armor stand facing each other in the center of the room. The Puzzle (Symbolic Loyalty): The two suits of armor are completely bare. One statue stands upright, while the other is locked in a kneeling posture. To represent the tradition of a nobleman knighting a protector, the players must search the room to find two specific objects: The Nobleman's Crown: Hidden inside a nearby storage chest. The Vanguard Greatsword: A ceremonial blade leaning against a rack in the corner. The Solution: The players must place the crown onto the head of the standing suit of armor and slide the ceremonial blade into its iron gauntlets. They must then move the armored arms so the flat of the blade rests gently upon the shoulders of the kneeling armor, completing the symbolic knighting ritual. The Transition: The moment the blade touches the iron shoulder, the metal glows red-hot, and the fire on the exit door instantly snuffs out.

THE MEMORY REVELATION

Lines of crackling fire snake across the stone floor, projecting a glowing, silent illusion of the past against the far wall. The illusion depicts the Baron and his visibly pregnant wife standing side-by-side inside this very room, standing and talking naturally with their loyal butler.

READ ALOUD TO PLAYERS

As the fire settles, words begin to sear themselves deeply into the stone wall beneath the glowing illusion, revealing the true dialogue of that night: The Baron: "We know what we are asking of you is a heavy burden, old friend. But if the darkness ever falls, and the day comes where we cannot stand by our son's side through his most troubled times... will you bind your spirit to his? Will you be his Sworn Shield, and protect his flame when ours has gone cold?" The Butler: "With my blade, my life, and my very soul, my Lord. Always."

ROOM 4: THE COLLAPSED SALON (THE ULTIMATE SACRIFICE)

This room is a grand salon, but it looks incredibly hazardous. Huge, heavy wooden support beams from the ceiling hang precariously overhead, suspended by thin, frayed cords of magical energy. The Hazard (The Falling Beams): As soon as the players step toward the center of the room, a loud crack echoes from above. One of the massive ceiling beams snaps and begins falling directly toward a vulnerable area of the floor. The Puzzle (The Protecting Shield): In the corner of the room rests a massive, heavy iron tower shield engraved with the Baron's family crest. To solve the room and stop the debris from crushing the environment, one player must physically lift the heavy shield and move underneath the falling beam, holding it up to protect another player character or Grant. The Solution: The player holding the shield must succeed on a physical strength check to withstand the crushing weight of the falling timber. The Transition: The moment the beam hits the shield and is successfully held aloft, the structural danger freezes. The wood and iron ignite into glowing embers, and the roaring fire on the exit door instantly snuffs out.

THE MEMORY REVELATION

Lines of crackling fire snake across the stone floor, projecting a glowing, silent illusion of the past against the far wall. The illusion drops the players straight into the chaos of the great fire seven years ago. The room around them is engulfed in roaring flames. The Baron is desperately leading his butler toward the exit when a massive, burning support pillar begins to collapse directly over the butler's head.

READ ALOUD TO PLAYERS

Through the flickering haze of the memory, you see the Baron turn around just as the ceiling gives way. Without a second thought, the Baron throws himself forward, violently shoving his loyal butler out of harm's way. The massive, burning pillar crashes down directly onto the Baron, pinning him beneath a mountain of blazing timber. The butler screams, desperately trying to claw at the burning wood, but the Baron looks up through the flames with a calm, final resolve. The Baron: "Go! Save the boy! Remember your vow... be his Sworn Shield!"

ROOM 5: THE GALLERY OF THE WRATH (THE CHILD'S NAME)

This long room is filled with mirrors and grand oil paintings of the Baron during his glory days. Grant must be in this room with at least one player character. The Puzzle: Among the artwork is a prominent oil painting depicting the Baron standing shoulder-to-shoulder with his loyal butler. To solve the room, a player must lift this specific portrait and place it directly in front of one of the large mirrors on the wall. The Transition: The moment the painting reflects in the mirror, the butler's image in the mirror morphs into the Sworn-Shield Wraith. Suddenly, a blast of fire erupts out of the physical glass, catching the oil painting on fire and tearing it to ash in seconds. The Ambush: The sudden flash of fire forces the players in the room to spin around. Standing right behind them in the physical room is the Sworn-Shield Wraith itself, its blazing eyes locked onto whoever is closest to Grant. The Voice: As the wraith's flames crackle wildly, the players hear only the destructive roar of an inferno. Grant, however, stands completely paralyzed as he alone hears the voice whisper from the fire: "None shall harm the Baron." The wraith glares with intense hostility at anyone standing within weapon range of Grant, acting as a lethal, silent warning. The Reveal: As the painting finishes burning to ash on the floor, the glowing embers rearrange themselves on the stone tiles to spell out a single, glowing name: GRANT. The fire on the exit door snuffs out as the wraith vanishes back into the architecture.

ROOM 6: THE NURSERY (THE ABDUCTION & THE CULPRIT)

This room was once a beautiful nursery, now perfectly preserved but filled with an unsettling, heavy silence. The Puzzle: Sitting on a rocking chair in the center of the room is a beautifully bound family photo album. As the players flip through it, they notice a page has been entirely torn out—the page detailing the Baron's infant son. In its place, a crude, forged note in a strange, heavy handwriting claims the child died in the nursery. The Solution: The players must cross-reference the forged handwriting with items in the room, or realize the handwriting matches a document Grant might have brought from home, proving his "Guardian" is the one who altered the book. The Reveal: The moment the forgery is exposed, a terrifying illusory shadow sears itself onto the nursery wall with lines of crackling fire. It shows the silhouette of a massive, monstrous Ogre snatching the baby Grant from his crib while a fire breaks out in the background. The text burns into the wall: "The guardian is the thief. The monster wears a human face." The fire on the final door snuffs out, clearing the path straight back downstairs.

THE MANOR ESCAPE: THE BURNING WALLS

SCENE 1: THE BODYGUARD'S BLINDNESS

The moment the players step out of Room 6 and back into the second-floor corridor, the immaculately preserved manor begins to violently vibrate. The temperature in the hallway spikes instantly. From the center of the grand foyer downstairs, a column of pure orange flame erupts, stretching all the way to the vaulted ceiling. Stepping out of the column is the Sworn-Shield Wraith. The Threat: The Wraith's glowing crimson eyes lock onto the player characters. Because of its singular, ancient directive ("Protect the Baron's bloodline"), it views the heavily armed adventurers standing near the vulnerable Grant as an immediate, mortal danger. It does not understand that the players are trying to help. The Burning Environment: As the Wraith charges up the grand staircase, it lashes out wildly with its massive hands. Its elongated, razor-sharp claws tear deep, violent gouges into the wood and stone walls. Wherever those white-hot claws strike, they leave glowing, molten claw marks that instantly erupt into roaring orange flames. Within seconds, the entire corridor becomes completely engulfed in fire. The Exception: The Wraith completely ignores Grant. It will actively sweep past him, using its massive claws to slash, burn, and incinerate anything or anyone else standing within weapon distance of the boy.

SCENE 2: CHOOSE YOUR FATE (COMBAT OR CHASE)

The hallway is collapsing, and the players have two distinct choices to survive this burning gauntlet:

- **OPTION A: THE ALL-OUT BATTLE** If the players stand their ground, they must fight a terrifyingly lethal force of nature while dodging falling debris from the clawed-up walls. At the start of every combat round, chunks of the burning ceiling collapse due to the deep claw marks. Players must dodge falling embers or take structural fire damage. The Mechanical Rule: The players can fight and defeat the Wraith to force a temporary opening. However, the Wraith cannot be destroyed permanently because it still has a job to complete. If reduced to 0 health, its bone framework shatters and dissolves into a cloud of harmless sparks, giving the players a brief window to run out the front doors before the fire pulls the creature back together.
- **OPTION B: THE AGILITY ESCAPE (THE CHASE)** If the players attempt to sprint down the grand staircase as the walls burn around them, every escaping player must succeed on a high-difficulty Agility check. On a success, the player seamlessly ducks under a sweeping claw, dives past a falling wall panel, and bursts through the front doors. On a failure, the player gets cornered by the roaring flames or struck by a heavy bone fist, taking major fire damage before scrambling out of the doors. Grant easily runs out alongside them, untouched by the fire.

ACT III: THE TOWN SQUARE SHOWDOWN

SCENE 1: THE DISGUISE SHATTERS

As the party escapes the burning noble district and races back toward the lower town square, they find the settlement in utter chaos. Standing in the center of the panicked town square is the Guardian. Exposed and realizing her seven-year secret is completely unraveled, she sheds her human disguise entirely.

READ ALOUD TO PLAYERS

The warm, comforting facade of the weary mother is completely gone. In the center of the town square, the Guardian's skin tears away, revealing a hideous, massive, slate-gray hide. Her muscles swell to grotesque proportions, and her jaw distends into a row of jagged, yellowed fangs. Standing over nine feet tall, the monstrous Ogre lets out a deafening roar that rattles the surrounding shop windows. Her eyes lock onto Grant, and she slams a massive fist into the stone pavement. The Ogre: "He belongs to me! Seven years I hid him from the ash, and I will tear this entire town apart before I let you take what is mine!"

SCENE 2: THE FINAL BATTLE

The final boss fight begins. The players must use everything they have to survive against her overwhelming brute strength.

THE OGRE'S COMBAT STYLE

Crushing Might: She uses her massive fists to smash the ground, creating shockwaves that can knock player characters off their feet. Desperation: She will actively try to push past the frontline players to grab Grant, knocking over carts and market stalls to clear her path.

THE CLIMAX: GRANT'S LEGACY

During the heat of the battle, the party struggles against the Ogre's overwhelming power. The monster delivers a devastating blow that knocks the players back, smashing market stalls and cornering Grant against the town fountain. This is where Grant's hereditary gift—and the truth of his magic—is fully realized.

READ ALOUD TO PLAYERS

Pinned against the cold stone of the fountain, Grant scrambles backwards as the massive Ogre steps closer, her yellowed fangs bared in triumph. In his panic, Grant's hand brushes against a small, charred object half-buried in the soot beside the fountain. It is an old, metallic pocket watch bearing the crest of the Baron's household staff—the pocket watch that belonged to his late butler, left behind in the ash seven years ago. As his fingers lock around the metal casing, the memories of the butler's gentle care rush through his mind. Grant's eyes ignite with a piercing crimson fire. He squeezes the watch in his fist, and a sudden, violent spark of pure flame erupts from his hand, entirely consuming the metal memorabilia. Grant throws his burning palm forward, sacrificing the watch to initiate the ancient bloodline vow. A massive pillar of fire shoots up from the cobblestones right in front of the Ogre. Stepping out of the blazing vortex is the Sworn-Shield Wraith. Armed with its sharp bone teeth and towering horns, it lets out a deep, echoing roar. It stands directly between the monster and the boy, its massive, razor-sharp claws clicking together. Grant has bound his Sworn Shield to his soul forever.

RESOLUTION

With the Sworn-Shield Wraith now fully under Grant's command, it turns its fury entirely upon the Ogre. The Wraith handles the brute force of the monster, leaving its white-hot claw marks across the Ogre's hide, while the player characters deliver the final, coordinating tactical strikes to finish her off, sending her crashing down into the dust of the town square.

EPILOGUE: THE BIRTH OF A HERO

With the threat permanently ended, the supernatural fires across Embres gently calm down, transforming into a soft, protective amber glow. Grant chooses to remain in the town of Embres. Deeply inspired by the sacrifices made by his birth parents, his loyal butler, and the adventurers who saved him, the young boy steps out of the shadows of anonymity. Supported by the townspeople—including Bram and his daughters, Amber, Ash, and Eve—he formally claims his family heritage. From that day forward, he is known by a brand new title: Grant, Baron of Flame. The campaign closes on a triumphant note as the young boy begins his training to become the true hero and rightful protector of Embres.



D20

THE BARON OF FLAME